Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version B

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. For multiple choice, fill in the circle next to the best answer. For the others, write on the lines.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. At dinner on Monday, what does Kiran believe about Biscuit?

A. He is sure she has started to trust him.

B. He is hurt that she does not like him as much as Dev.

C. He is sure she has not eaten any of his food.

D. He is afraid she has gotten sick.

2. On Tuesday, why does Kiran tell Tam that Biscuit hates him?

A. She slipped away when he waved a toy and sang to her.

B. She hissed at him when he reached under the bed with a treat.

C. She ran right past him when he crouched down by the couch.

D. She sat on the armchair and turned her back on him the whole time.

3. By Thursday, what has Kiran most likely figured out about what brings Biscuit close to him?

A. sitting still on the floor and waiting for her to come

B. humming to her softly from across the room

C. resting on the armchair where she likes to nap

D. working on his homework where she can see him

4. Why does the author describe the blanket on the armchair in paragraph 3?

A. to hint that Biscuit had come out to rest there while Kiran was at school

B. to hint that Biscuit had slipped out to eat while Dev was over that afternoon

C. to hint that Biscuit had hidden under it all day instead of eating her food

D. to hint that Biscuit had napped on it at dawn, before the bowl was filled

5. On Monday morning, what does Kiran do to try to get Biscuit to come out? Quote one sentence that shows it, and give its paragraph number.

Answer: _____

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The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

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Questions 6-10: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, in what year did Selk's students build the nesting platforms?

A. 1961 **B.** 1968 **C.** 1980 **D.** 1971

7. Why had no one on Vessa Island seen what was happening to the new shoots before 1968?

A. It happened underwater, where no one could see the shoots.

B. It happened after dark, when no one was out on the mud.

C. It happened in winter, when the islanders stayed off the shore.

D. It happened deep in the reed clumps, where the mud was hidden from view.

8. For several summers after the platforms went up, the new shoots kept vanishing. Based on the article, what most likely explains the delay?

A. The snails had eaten the roots, which take years to regrow.

B. The new pairs nested in the South Lagoon for a few summers.

C. At first there were too few drells to eat down all the kibs.

D. The storm's salt took several more years to wash out of the mud.

9. What does the article tell us about drells and young fish?

A. Selk watched the birds at night and saw them eat snails, not fish.

B. No one had ever seen a drell eat one, and the catch held when they returned.

C. The catch dipped for a few years after the birds came back, and then it slowly recovered.

D. Fishermen had spotted drells taking a few fish before 1961, but never many.

10. What does "clumps" mean as it is used in paragraph 5? Name another paragraph that helps you know, and tell what it says.

Answer: _____

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CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

11. By the end of "Biscuit," how is Kiran different from the boy who started the job on Monday? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer.

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